

"The private sector has always been involved. The only difference now, which is a big difference, is that private people can be mission owners"

SRINATH RAVICHANDRAN
CO-FOUNDER AND CEO, AGNIKUL COSMOS

tion only a few years ago, could convert Isro's know-how and its inherited base of suppliers into hardware of its own.

THE ISRO INHERITANCE

Much of what private companies are building today rests on six decades of work by India's state-owned space agency, the Indian Space Research Organisation, or Isro. Before 2020, Isro was India's only face in space. It designed the rockets and also built various satellites. Since 1979, the agency has done more than 100 launches and put satellites into orbit, and even sent missions to the Moon (Chandrayaan) and Mars (Mangalyaan).

Formed in 1969, Isro succeeded the Indian National Committee for Space Research, which India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, had established under the Department of Atomic Energy in 1962. Born out of the need for communications, weather forecasting, remote sensing and development of a young, and impoverished, republic, it prioritised reliability, frugal engineering and self-reliance.

Over the next six decades, Isro built a base of more than 500 companies—public and private—across India, with dense clusters around Bengaluru, Thiruvananthapuram, Ahmedabad, Hyderabad and Sriharikota.

By Isro's own estimates, around 80-85% of launch-vehicle inputs come from this network of roughly 500 small to large industries. These suppliers were, and largely still are, geared towards build-to-spec fabrication.

Manish Gupta, general partner at growX Ventures and an early investor in Bellatrix, calls it built-to-print. "Isro developed the designs and owned the technology, it sourced or made the components; vendors received the finalised drawings," says Gupta. "They had to build it precisely to a drawing or specification handed to them and did a very good job of it." That robust supplier base, and its capabilities of building to print, are genuine strengths. But they represent only one part of a space innovation ecosystem. Mission design, system configuration, components development, sensor integration, and the firmware and software that give most subsystems their intelligence were not part of that supplier base's capability.

The question every spacetech founder in India had to answer was how much of the existing aerospace and defence manufacturing base they could actually use. For heavy manufacturing, the answer was: most of it. Sanjay Nekkanti, Co-founder and CEO of Hyderabad-based Dhruva Space, started his company in 2012 on

TAKING OFF

PE-VC investment in Indian spacetech rose from around $10 million in 2020 to around $350 million in 2026



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